Writing ten years after the fact, General Hoffmann marvelled at the amount of preliminary work, coordination and military expertise required to carry out such an operation. Regular handwritten reports on the project's progress were handed to both Ulbricht and the Russian Ambassador, Mikhail Pervuchin.

Although Khrushchev had still not committed to building a wall, Ulbricht's impatience on the issue was highlighted by Pervuchin in a letter to Foreign Minister Gromyko on 19 May, in which he detailed plans by the SED leadership to 'immediately close the border' between East and West Berlin, against Soviet policy.

Our friends [the SED] would now like to impose a control on the sector border between democratic Berlin and West Berlin, enabling them 'to shut the door to the West', as they call it, to reduce the exodus of people from the Republic and to weaken the influence of the economic conspiracy initiated against the GDR by West Berlin.

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As Ulbricht was told to sit tight, the international situation remained difficult and dangerous. At a summit in Vienna on 4 June 1961, between US President John F. Kennedy and Khrushchev, the two discussed numerous issues but there was no breakthrough regarding Berlin. Then, in late July, Kennedy's disarmament adviser John McCloy met with Khrushchev in Sochi on the Black Sea, where the Soviet leader expressed doubt about whether the Western powers were willing to fight to defend their rights in Berlin. Russian diplomat Valentin Falin, employed in the Germany department of the Moscow Foreign Ministry, recounted that Khrushchev had informed McCloy 'broadly about what action [in Berlin] was to come.'5 The tension finally came to a head on 25 July, when, in a live broadcast to the nation, Kennedy announced he had formulated 'three